r/WhatIfThinking • 4d ago
u/Ambitious-Special479

What if daylight saving happened gradually?

https://gradual.johndimm.org

Could we get the benefits of DST without the downside of abrupt shifts back and forth in time?

Seasons change gradually and so should our clocks. Not with current systems but someday. In the meantime you can change your internal clock gradually.

The interesting whatif: suppose there were a single source of truth for time. Not the case in general since every clock is a source of truth. But there is for cellphones. **When was the last time you set the clock on your phone?** The time is what the network says. That means to track seasons, we no longer have to limit changes to two abrupt interventions. The changes could be continuous. There is no cost to updating all devices at once.

So imagine a future where all time devices are networked. Stand-alone real time clocks are valuable relics. We implement daylight saving at the network level. What would be the consequences?

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xienwolf • 4d ago

This link goes to an adjusting alarm clock. So you personally move your day back and forth by an hour.

As long as it is about your bedtime and nothing else, go for it. Anybody can do it if they want.

The arguments around daylight time or not are all about going to/from work/school in the dark.

To address that with this gradual method would mean “when does school/work start” has a different answer every single day. Scheduling would be an absolute nightmare.

DragonFireCK • 4d ago • Edited 4d ago

Honestly, we operated with that type of system for millennium. Prior to widespread clocks, electric lighting, and fast transport, the day would begin at sunrise and end at sunset.

The length of hours shifted - the period from sunrise to sunset was 12 hours, whether it was the summer solstice, winter solstice, or any day in between. This started changing scientific proposes around 200 BCE, but common people only shifted around 1300 CE.

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The ideal scenario would be to do something like make every clock-second be 999ms for half the year, and 1001ms for the other half of the year. To humans, it would be absolutely imperceptible... but would be equivalent to changing the clock by approximately a minute and a half per day. Sunrise, sunset, and day length would still wobble and drift a bit from week to week... but for the most part, you'd barely notice anything except around January and August (when the shift would briefly overtake the daily grind before snapping back and becoming normal again).

The downside is... it would make every legacy clock and wristwatch functionally obsolete. At best, someone with a $20,000 Rolex or antique clock would have to accept that it gains or loses approximately 90 seconds per day, depending on which half of the year it is.

Ambitious-Special479 OP • 2d ago

You got it! The elastic second.

PvtRoom • 4d ago

what we should really do is just say noon is when the sun is highest in the sky, and just let every city & small region have their own timezone, and set their own times for things like school (school starts 1hr after sunrise)

trains & plane timetables might need help.

Psycho_Pansy • 3d ago

So I have to research and memorize the time differences of every city and region in my area? What an absolute pain for scheduling work and appointments.

PvtRoom • 3d ago

the Edwardians managed.

Aggressive-Leading45 • 3d ago

If I ask you what time it is in Perth do you research it and do the math or do you just look at your phone's world clock and see what time it is. These days where arithmetic isn't taught even east coasters just look at the phone to see what time it is in Denver. Phones and computers already do timezones by urban area. Meeting software already corrects for timezones.

testmonkeyalpha • 4d ago

Time zones exist because they make coordination much easier. Prior to time zones, people set their watches based on local noon (sun directly overhead). Nobody knew what time a train would arrive/depart.

This solution creates a new version of the no time zone problem between regions that use DST and regions that do not. It makes scheduling across regions a nightmare.

Imagine a very common scenario: People living in two different time zones are setting up a meeting. One observes DST and one doesn't. During the entire transitional period, there will be no "good" time to start the meeting. A 30 minute meeting will take up an entire 1 hour slot for one group because it doesn't fit nicely in a standard 30 minute

The best solution (assuming DST stays) is literally the concept behind the alarm clock you shared. People adjust their own personal schedules over time to avoid the abruptness.

Savings_Difficulty24 • 3d ago • Edited 3d ago

As someone who used to do swing shift (alternate day shift and night shift every two weeks), this discussion always annoys me. I flip my schedule an entire 12 hours every two weeks, and y'all can't handle a single hour every 6 months. It only takes me a day to recover, and here people act like everything is ruined for a month over daylight savings. Talk about first world problems. It's an inconvenience at most. Especially when everyone changes their schedule on the weekends anyways. Sleeping in 3-4 hours longer than normal, then going right back to getting up for work/school first thing Monday morning. Hell, this is the good time flip, we get to sleep in an hour this time.

More-Explanation2788 • 3d ago

All this clock adjustment gives people jet lag and causes fatal accidents. Changing the clocks is just stupid.

We need to tell the people who think it is a good idea: We are not all getting jet lag once a year just so you can pretend you don’t go to bed early in the summer. Buy an alarm clock and bugger off.

Thornescape • 1d ago

Or... how about... if daylight savings time never happened at all because it's a stupid idea?

ActuaLogic • 4d ago

Are there benefits to daylight savings time? That's not clear. To me, the benefits can be strained by eliminating daylight savings time and going to year-round standard time. As a compromise, I suggest moving the clocks back one-half hour in the fall and leaving them that way throughout the year.

StevInPitt • 3d ago

i once mapped this out in excel.. the clock would have to shift something like 20 seconds a day longer and then shorter between the winter and summer solstices.
easy to do and no one would ever notice.
Winter solstice, the clock would have shifted an entire hour "earlier" and then by summer solstice it would be an hour "later.".
Even manual clocks and watches could be kept roughly in line by shifting 2 and 1/2 minutes a week or 10 minutes a month.
I think it would be an elehant solution and easy to achieve.

Quantumquandary • 3d ago

It already does. It gets lighter later and darker earlier. Then it changes back. And check this out, it already happens on the same days, every year.

would be fare MORE hassle.

I don't care whether we do standard time or daylight savings, we should just pick one and stick with it.

shootdowntactics • 3d ago

This would really mess up any international trade. One country would still have the current system, while the other would do this wacky thing. Move a meeting one day later and everyone wonders why the start time is suddenly 11:04 instead of on the hour.

_litz • 3d ago

The entire IT industry would like to have a word (or three)

Recent-Day3062 • 4d ago

The practical problems with this are enormous

Psycho_Pansy • 3d ago

Should go to standard time. Then schools and businesses can adjust their operating times to start/end an hour early when and if they choose to if they desire more or less time in the sun.

JaiBoltage • 3d ago

>suppose there were a single source of truth for time.

UTC

new_refugee123456789 • 3d ago

WHAT benefits of daylight savings?

Daylight savings time is the product of feeding a generation of children beatings and lead from birth to 14. The logic of daylight savings goeth thusly:

I have a doctor's appointment at 8 AM. I wake up at 6 AM. It'll take me an hour to get up, get breakfast, get ready and drive to the doctor's office. So that'll be 7 AM. So let's change all the clocks everywhere by an hour so that my appointment happens at 7 instead of 8, so that I can wake up at 6 AM.